and social pressures better. Its focus on self-realisation rather than collective advancement, they say, might allow plenty of room for philosophical thought, but none for collective action. To such critics, this prevents Hindus from constituting a defined 'community' that can withstand external pressures. Such thinking partly animates the Hindutva project we shall discuss in Chapter Five.

The *Atharva Veda* points out that the quest for awareness, the search for answers, the journey towards self-realisation, never ceases:

> *How does the wind not cease to blow?*
> *How does the mind take no repose?*
> *Why do the waters, seeking to reach the truth,*
> *Never at any time cease to flow?*
>
> — *Atharva Veda*, X.7.37[17]

And yet this process is not purely self-centred individualism, since the real self one discovers in this profound quest is the same self as everyone else's. Self-realisation leads ultimately to merging one's soul into the collective Brahman. So when one goes to a temple to worship, one is finding a common sanctified space to help one travel to the same destination as every other worshipper.